

Power and Privilege Symposium Reflection

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The Power and Privilege Symposium is a Whitman event meant to celebrate the intellectual curiosity and interests of the Whitman community. It features various talks, discussion panels, and performances meant to open the conversation on structural oppression both at Whitman College and beyond. Among the talks I attended, one particularly caught my interest due to its resonance with my country's dark history. It was titled "*Who Gets to Belong: Power, Ethnicity, and the Politics of Identity*", presented by Kathleen Purnama, an international student from Indonesia. She told the history of the racist and ethnic cleansing of the Chinese-Indonesian population in her country, demonstrating the horrific effects of discriminatory practices.

To a Western physicist established in the global north, Purnama's story might register like just yet another remote story from the global south. But the roots underneath the Chinese-Indonesian discrimination are everywhere, even in the seemingly egalitarian world of physics, where the truth alone is supposed to rule.

An example of this is the *Matilda Effect*, a term coined by historian Margaret Rossiter. Rossiter observed that the contributions of female scientists tend to be neglected and sometimes attributed to their male counterparts (Rossiter, 1993). A poignant illustration of this is Lise Meitner, the first scientist to explain nuclear fission, yet she watched the 1944 Nobel Prize be awarded solely to her male collaborator.

Though the scientific community has improved since Meitner's time, research shows that non-white physicists face systemic inequalities across every stage of their careers, from undergraduate education to senior faculty positions. Eaton et al. (Eaton et al., 2020) reported that race and gender stereotypes continue to shape evaluations and advancement in STEM

fields, including physics. Research in physics education further suggests that recognition within classrooms is not distributed equally; gender and racial biases can shape which students are perceived as strong in physics, even beyond academic performance (Sundstrom et al., 2022). Carlana et al. (Carlana et al., 2023) found that in Italy, a large majority of teachers exhibited moderate to severe implicit bias against immigrant students.

Recent studies in “White Empiricism” suggest that the social prestige of certain scientists biases reviewers to be less rigorous in their critique, while marginalized scientists face hyper-scrutiny. A 2020 study by Professor David M. Quinn found that white and female teachers graded identical writing samples lower when they believed the author was Black (Quinn, 2020).

Despite the efforts of institutions like Whitman College to foster community and inclusion, inequality persists, even in the pantheon of science, where the truth is supposed to be King of Gods. While we have seen progress in representation, such as the increasing number of women and people of color entering STEM, equity and inclusion still lag. To address this, it is not enough to invite more people into academia. We must be aware of ingrained biases and strive to value people for their work, not their social privileges. For example, scientists can engage in implicit bias training and use tools like the Implicit Association Test (IAT) to become aware of personal biases. Research suggests that clearly-defined grading rubrics reduce subjective bias by focusing evaluators on specific standards of mastery rather than preconceived expectations.

Institutions should strive to give students from minority groups the opportunities they did not have access to before, to help close the gap with their more privileged peers, and the curriculum should be malleable enough to meet students where they are, rather than setting standards that disregard the reality of where they come from.

References

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